

# Why We Forget

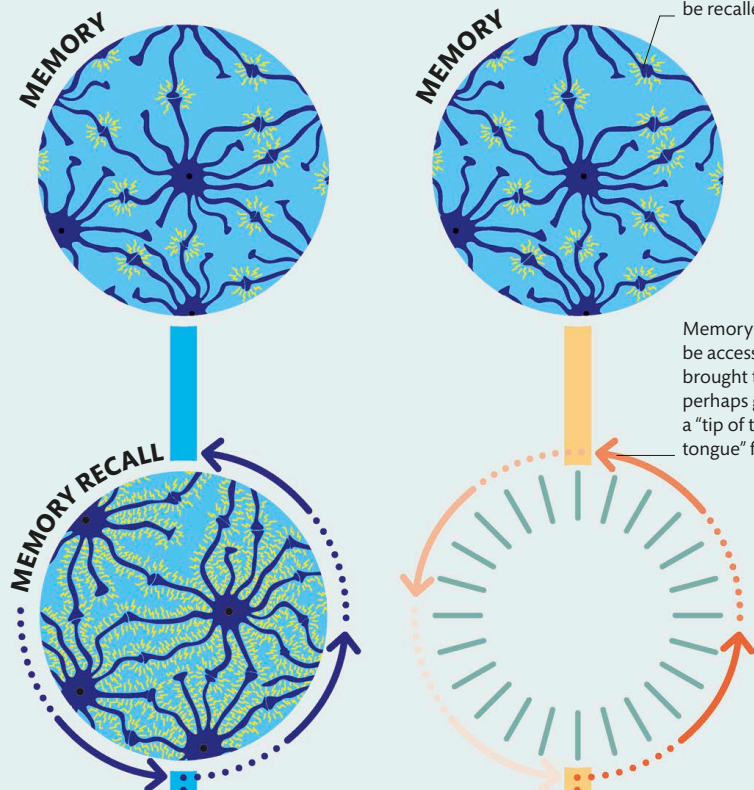
There are many theories to explain why we forget things. Some scientists think that all our memories remain in our brains but that we sometimes lose the ability to access them. Our memories may also interfere with one another.

## Forgetting in the brain

There are many conditions that cause us to forget (see pp.146–147). Broadly, there are two possibilities for what happens in the brain when we do. The simplest idea is that over time memories fade away; information is lost as the trace that was formed is no longer there. But evidence for this is hard to come by, as other factors could be involved. Most of us have experienced the struggle to remember information that later pops into your head for no reason—this suggests memories can still exist but be inaccessible. This could be because other similar memories are interfering with them, or because there is no cue in our environment to prompt that recall. It is not known whether the nerve-cell connections of a memory disappear or if they still exist but we are unable to access them.

### WHY DO I FORGET WHAT I WENT UPSTAIRS FOR?

Leaving a room changes the environmental cues that help us remember. When you go back to where you were, the memory often reactivates.



Memory trace exists in brain; often, blockage is later released and memory can be recalled

Memory cannot be accessed or brought to mind, perhaps giving a "tip of the tongue" feeling

#### Memory retrieved

When we recall something, we must reactivate the network of neurons that stores it. If this is successful, we remember the fact or event.

#### Failure to retrieve

If recall is unsuccessful, it may be that the memory is still in the cortex, we are just unable to access it (above). Or connections may have been lost (see right).